

Spaghetti with sweet pepper and extra virgin olive oil sauce

Take advantage of the sweetest, plumpest bell peppers and seasonal ripe tomatoes you can find. When beefsteaks are red and juicy, they're wonderful. If you have access to any variety—or a mix—of heirloom tomatoes, consider yourself blessed. And when all the others look a little peaked, chances are the plum tomatoes will make a tasty sauce. Use your best extra virgin olive oil as well.

2½ pounds fresh ripe tomatoes [2.25kg]

1½ teaspoons salt

1 large onion, thinly sliced

¼ cup extra virgin olive oil [60ml]

3 garlic cloves, minced

1 celery rib, chopped

½ red bell pepper, thinly sliced

½ yellow pepper, thinly sliced

1 carrot, halved lengthwise, thinly sliced

1 tablespoon dried oregano

1 teaspoon cinnamon

1 teaspoon fennel seeds

½ teaspoon crushed hot red pepper

¼ teaspoon freshly ground black pepper

1 tablespoon unrefined cane sugar

1 pound spaghetti [500g]

Handful of fresh basil leaves, thinly sliced

Freshly grated Parmesan cheese

1. **Score** a shallow X with a sharp paring knife along the bottom of each tomato. Drop in boiling water for 30 to 60 seconds. Remove with a slotted spoon and run under cold water or drop in a bowl of ice water. Peel off the skin. Coarsely chop the tomatoes and set aside with their juices.
2. In a large flameproof casserole, **simmer** the tomatoes uncovered with 1 teaspoon of the salt for about 45 minutes, stirring occasionally, mashing down chunky pieces with the back of a spoon. The tomatoes will reduce and sweeten during this time.

3. Meanwhile, in another skillet, **cook** the onion in 2 tablespoons of the olive oil over medium heat until soft but not brown, about 5 minutes. Add the garlic, celery, bell peppers, and carrot and continue to cook for another 3 or 4 minutes, or until the vegetables are very soft and the onion is golden.
4. **Add** the oregano, cinnamon, fennel seeds, hot pepper, $\frac{1}{2}$ teaspoon salt, black pepper, and sugar. Cook, stirring, for an additional 1 to 2 minutes, or until the spices are very fragrant.
5. Add the onion and vegetables to the simmering tomato sauce. Continue to cook, **stirring** occasionally, for another 20 minutes, or until the flavors are just right for you. Season with additional salt and pepper to taste. Remove from the heat and stir in the remaining 2 tablespoons oil.
6. While the sauce is cooking, bring at least 4 quarts [4L] salted water to a vigorous boil. **Add** the pasta and stir immediately and often until the water returns to a boil. Cook until the pasta is al dente (slightly resistant to the bite), then drain it quickly into a colander. Shake out the water completely and transfer to plates. Immediately top with the sauce, garnish with fresh basil, and pass the cheese on the side.

SERVES 4

